

Press Release**COMPREHENSIVE STATE-WIDE RAPTOR ASSESSMENT**

Tamil Nadu is a significant habitat for raptors, hosting over 65 raptor species of the orders Accipitriformes, Falconiformes, and Strigiformes. Raptors are keystone species and provide various ecosystem services, and are considered bio-indicators of environmental health. The Western Ghats, Eastern Ghats, and coastal wetlands of Tamil Nadu are vital raptor habitats. Decline of raptors globally hinders the ecosystem functions of birds of prey, including pollination, seed dispersal, scavenging, and predation.

The Tamil Nadu Raptor Research Foundation (TNRRF) which was established in July, 2025 serves as a state-level governing body dedicated to the conservation of birds of prey in Tamil Nadu. The foundation is housed at the Advanced Institute for Wildlife Conservation (AIWC) in Vandalur, Chennai. The foundation leads and coordinates conservation efforts to protect the wild populations of raptors. Through focused scientific research, habitat preservation, and capacity-building, the foundation is dedicated to producing vital knowledge on raptor biology and ecology.

The Raptor Conservation Programme team of the World Wildlife Fund-India (WWF-India) have joined hands with the TNRRF team at AIWC in advancing raptor conservation in Tamil Nadu.

The first comprehensive state-wide raptor assessment was successfully conducted across all divisions on 31st January and 1st February 2026. A total of 389 blocks were surveyed across 49 forest divisions across Tamil Nadu involving 3643 mandays, 7959 km of vehicle survey and 2115 km of foot survey. The survey recorded a total of 5712 sightings. During the survey, a total of 51 raptor species belonging to 5 families, namely, Pandionidae, Accipitridae, Falconidae, Tytonidae and Strigidae were recorded.

Hon'ble Minister of Forests and Hon'ble Minister of Environment released the first Comprehensive State-Wide Raptor Assessment Report on 5th June, 2026 on the occasion of World Environment Day recognising it as an exercise to complement understanding of their population, biology and ecology, and conserve raptor species.

**Additional Chief Secretary to Government
Environment, Climate Change and Forest Department**

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